

Parotid (Stensen's) duct

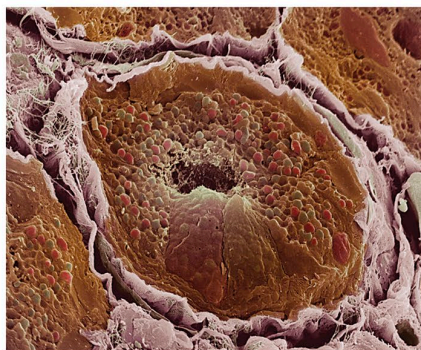
Opens into cheek lining, next to the upper second molar tooth

Accessory parotid gland**Parotid gland**

Largest of three paired salivary glands; produces watery saliva

SALIVARY GLANDS

Saliva is made by three pairs of salivary glands: the parotid glands, positioned in front of and just below each ear; the submandibulars, on the inner sides of the lower jawbone (mandible); and the sublinguals, in the floor of the mouth, below the tongue. In addition, many small accessory glands are found in the mucous membranes lining the mouth and tongue. Although it is composed of 99.5 per cent water, saliva also contains important solutes such as amylase, a digestive enzyme that begins the breakdown of starches, and salts. Saliva lubricates food to make chewing and swallowing easier, and it keeps the mouth moist between periods of eating.

**SALIVARY GLAND STRUCTURE**

Many small, rounded glandular units called acini (brown), separated by connective tissue (pink), discharge their saliva into tiny central ducts. Acinar ducts converge into the main saliva-carrying glandular ducts.

Larynx (voicebox)

Oesophagus (gullet)

Trachea (windpipe)